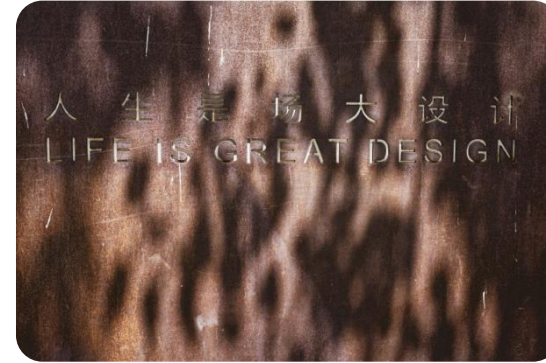


Beyond East and West: Value Orientations in Chinese and Western Proverbs

Are proverbs cultural mirrors or cultural stereotypes?

Here, “Western proverbs” mainly refers to common English proverbs used in Anglophone contexts.



What Value Orientations Do They Suggest?



- I. 众人拾柴火焰高
- II. 天助自助者
- III. Many hands make light work
- IV. God helps those who help themselves

有些谚语看似来自不同文化，却表达了相似的价值；有些中文表达本身也可能来自西方译介。



Why Proverbs ?

“Proverbs and sayings as a universal form of discourse undoubtedly present themselves as a **window** into values and beliefs of a given culture where these proverbial phrases are found.”

“Proverbs and sayings are one of the key **emic value carriers** and **transmitters**.”

谚语不仅是语言表达，也是文化内部长期流传的价值判断。

中西谚语中的典型 Value Orientations

Self and Group

众人拾柴火焰高

God helps those who
help themselves

collective effort vs
self-reliance

Caution and Action

三思而后行

Nothing ventured,
nothing gained

prudence vs risk-
taking

Family and Home

家和万事兴

A man's home is his
castle

family harmony vs
domestic privacy



中西谚语也有很多相似价值



Shared Value	Chinese Proverb	Western Proverb
Hard work	一分耕耘，一分收获	No pain, no gain
Value of time	一寸光阴一寸金	Time is money
Preparation	未雨绸缪	A stitch in time saves nine
Experience	吃一堑，长一智	Experience is the best teacher

这些共同价值说明：很多谚语回应的是共同的人类经验，而不只是文化差异。

同一文化内部，也可能出现相反的 Value Orientations

Chinese

三思而后行
机不可失，时不再来

众人拾柴火焰高
靠人不如靠己

Anglophone

Look before you leap.
He who hesitates is lost.

Many hands make light work.
If you want a thing done well,
do it yourself.

谚语不是单一答案，而是不同情境下可被选择的价值资源。

Chinese Proverb-based Values: More Than Collectivism

不是单一的 collectivism, 而是多种价值的组合。

这些价值背后, 是 modern individualism 更强, 还是 traditional collectivism 更强?

Table 1
Values Reflected in the Frequently Listed Proverbs

BroadValue Themes	Values/ Cronbach's α	Examples of Chinese Proverbs	English Translation of the Proverbs
Achievement Orientation	Learnedness .83	活到老,学到老 读万卷书,行万里路 知识决定命运 知识就是力量	One is never too old to learn. Read a million books and travel a million miles. Knowledge determines fate. Knowledge is power.
	Diligence .92	天道酬勤 一寸光阴一寸金 天才就是99%的汗水 加上1%的灵感	Heaven rewards conscientiousness. An inch of time is worth an inch of gold. Genius is 99 percent perspiration and 1 percent inspiration.
	Practical orientation .87	天才在于勤奋 有志者,事竟成 天助自助者 细节决定成败	Genius lies in diligence. Nothing is impossible to a willing heart. God helps those who help themselves. The devil is in the details.
Social Harmony	Collective orientation .78	千里之行,始于足下 天下兴亡,匹夫有责 众人拾柴火焰高 一方有难,八方支援	A journey of a thousand miles begins with the first step. All men share a common responsibility for the fate of their country. Where many help to gather firewood, the flames shoot high. When trouble occurs at one spot, help comes from all quarters.
	Social relationship .88	独乐乐,不如众乐乐 忍一时风平浪静,退一步海阔天空 有朋自远方来,不亦说乎	Shared joy is a double joy. Yield for a moment, and the wind shall calm and the wave subside; take a step back, and the sea is broad and the sky open. Isn't it joyful to have a friend from afar.
	Moral virtue .85	严以律己,宽以待人 滴水之恩,当涌泉相报 己所不欲,勿施于人 百善孝为先 谦虚使人进步,骄傲使人落后	Be strict with oneself and lenient towards others. Kindness of a drop of water will be repaid with a flowing spring. Do not do to others what you do not want others to do to you. Filial piety is virtue of virtues. As conceit makes one lag behind, so modesty helps one make progress.
Free Spirit	Free spirit .81	地势坤,君子以厚德载物 走自己的路,让别人去说吧 不自由,勿宁死 非淡泊无以明志,非宁静无以致远	As heaven maintains vigor through movement, a gentleman should constantly strive for self-perfection. Follow your own course, and let people talk. I'd rather die than have no freedom. Nothing lasting can be accomplished without leading a quiet life.
		知足常乐 失败乃成功之母 天生我材必有用 明天又是新的一天 冬天已经到来,春天还会远吗?	Happiness is content. Failure is the mother of success. Heaven has endowed me with talent for eventual use. Tomorrow is another day. Winter has come, will spring be far away?
Optimism	Optimism .84		

Individualism vs Collectivism

Chinese young adults endorsed both individualism and collectivism, albeit they were more individualistic ($M = 5.13$) than collectivistic ($M = 4.79$).

Collectivism was a stronger predictor, albeit individualism was also a significant positive predictor, of the eight values.

这说明中国年轻人的价值结构并非简单“个人主义化”：

individualism 与 collectivism 同时存在，并共同影响他们对谚语价值的认同，而不是一种价值完全取代另一种价值。

Weng, L., Zhang, Y. B., Kulich, S. J., & Zuo, C. (2021). Cultural values in Chinese proverbs reported by Chinese college students. *Asian Journal of Social Psychology*, 24(2), 232-243.
<https://doi.org/10.1111/ajsp.12415>

全球化语境： 谚语会跨文化流动和再语境化

Chinese set expressions in
American discourse

315

cases

Different proverbs found

50

Non-China-related contexts

59%

“...resulting in total number of 315 cases with 50 different proverbs found.”

“...the predominance of that type of context, which comprised 59% of all analyzed examples...”

中国谚语进入 American discourse 后，不一定只服务于“中国主题”，也可能在更广泛的语境中被借用和再解释。



Conclusion: Proverbs are cultural mirrors, but not fixed cultural stereotypes

